I’m a design leader who helps organisations build great in-house teams and digital services

James Cook
Bristol, United Kingdom

Selected work on request

Seasoned designer with 20+ years’ experience leading people, shaping teams, improving design operations, and delivering complex software systems

hellojames.co.uk, linkedin.com/in/hellojames, adplist.org/mentors/james-cook

Experience

Design Mentor
2021–Pr • global • ADPList

Lead Consultant
2022–24 • SG/AU • Thoughtworks

Design Operations Lead;
User Experience Practice Lead
2017–21 • UK • OVO Energy

User Experience Lead
2015–17 • UK/DE/IN • Springer Nature

Experience Design Senior Consultant;
Experience Design Consultant
2012–15 • UK/SG/IN • Thoughtworks

User Experience Designer
2011–12 • UK • Loco2 (now RailEurope)

User Experience Analyst
2008–10 • UK • Isotrak

Web Developer
2007–08 • UK • Cambridge Assessment

2006–07 **Cyfle/Sequence Digital**
2005–06 **Afanti Media**

Study

Design for Visual Communication PGC
University of the Arts London

Design for Interactive Media BA
University of Wales, Cardiff

Multimedia Product Design HND
Cardiff School of Art & Design

Highlights

- Grew OVO’s practice from 5→50 people in two years, with 55/45 M/F balance
- Established Springer Nature’s global UX community and design operations
- Designed Amnesty’s emergency alert app, securing £100,000 Google funding
- Led Design for Singapore Government’s first agile transformation at scale
- Interviewed 400+ designers & researchers; Mentored 200+ people

Expertise

- Building and scaling design capability within organisations
- Establishing and sustaining communities of practice
- UX strategy, design operations, and delivery assurance
- Leading product design across complex, agile environments
- Embedding quality, accessibility, and scalability in software delivery

Strengths

- Analytical, structured thinking and pragmatic decision making
- Influencing stakeholders in prioritisation, planning, and trade-offs
- Hiring, team design, and defining ways of working
- Developing designers and fostering healthy team culture
- Helping design, product, and engineering work together more effectively
- Facilitating workshops for alignment and shared understanding
- Rapid exploration through visual thinking to build shared ownership
- Co-design and iterative delivery across disciplines
- Shaping solution direction, structure, and interaction design
- Enabling teams through servant leadership

Recognition

2025 ADPList Top 100 Mentors
2024 ADPList Top 100 Mentors
2019 OVO Values Heroes
2016 GovInsider Innovation Awards
2013 Google Global Impact Awards
2006 NESTA Innovate to Educate

People before pixels.

I've worked internationally with a wide range of clients across sectors

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thoughtworks
SELFRIDGES&CO
ovo energy
Singapore Government
SPRINGER NATURE
nature
BMC
Springer
GOV·UK
SLC Student Loans Company
UXThailand
ADPlist
CAMBRIDGE UNIVERSITY PRESS & ASSESSMENT
LIBERTY
AMNESTY INTERNATIONAL
standard chartered
HAWCROFT
janio
nti
xero
BT
RAIL EUROPE
ISOTRAK
Sequence
Labour
Liberal Democrats
BBC
afanti